

These specifications are in Google's 'Mobile Application Distribution Agreement- (MADA)' which was leaked in February 2014.

There are some exceptions in the market such as Amazon's Kindle Fire, which is based on the Android OS but doesn't feature the usual Google stuff and has Amazon's App Store instead of Google Play.

For a while, we all were convinced that Android was free and open to everyone. It may seem so on the surface but under the hood, Android is not so open. We all know that, at its core, Android has a Linux kernel, which is released under the GNU Public License, but that's only a part of Android. Many other components are licensed under the Apache licence, which allows the source code of Android to be distributed freely and not necessarily to be released to the public. Some mobile vendors make sure that their devices run their very own tailored Android version by preventing users from installing any other custom ROMs. A forcibly installed custom ROM in your Android will nullify the warranty of the device. So, most users are forced to keep the Android version shipped with the device.

Another frustrating aspect for Android users is with respect to the updates. In Android, updates are very complex, because there is no uniformity among the various devices running the Android OS. Even closed OSs support their updates—for example, Apple's iOS 5 supports iPhone 4, 4s, iPad and iPad 2; and Microsoft allows its users to upgrade to Windows 7 from Windows XP without hassles. As you have probably noticed, only a handful of devices receive the new Android version. The rest of the users are forced to change their phones. Most users are alright with that, because today, the life expectancy of mobiles is a maximum of about two years. People who want to stay updated as much as possible, change their phones within a year. The reason behind this mess is that updates depend mostly on the hardware, the specs of which differ from vendor to vendor. Most vendors upgrade their hardware specs as soon as a new Android version hits the market. So the next time you try to install an app which doesn't work well on your device, just remember, "It's time to change your phone!"

Android and freedom

Online privacy is becoming a myth, since security threats pose a constant challenge. No matter how hard we work to make our systems secure, there's always some kind of threat arising daily. That's why systems administrators continually evaluate security and take the necessary steps to mitigate threats.

Not long ago, we came to know about PRISM — an NSA (USA) spy program that can monitor anyone, anywhere in the world, at any time. Thanks to Edward Snowden, who leaked this news, we now realise how vulnerable we are online. Although some may think that worrying about this borders on being paranoid, there's sufficient proof that all this is happening as you read this article. Many of us use smartphones for almost everything. We keep business contacts, personal details, and

The following list features devices supported by Replicant and their corresponding Replicant versions.

- HTC Dream/HTC Magic: Replicant 2.2
- Nexus One: Replicant 2.3
- Nexus S: Replicant 4.2
- Galaxy S: Replicant 4.2
- Galaxy S2: Replicant 4.2
- Galaxy Note: Replicant 4.2
- Galaxy Nexus: Replicant 4.2
- Galaxy Tab 2 7.0: Replicant 4.2
- Galaxy Tab 2 10.1: Replicant 4.2
- Galaxy S3: Replicant 4.2
- Galaxy Note 2: Replicant 4.2
- GTA04: Replicant 2.3

Separate installation instructions for these devices can be found on the Replicant website.

confidential data such as bank account numbers, passwords, etc, on it. It's not an exaggeration to state that our smartphones contain more confidential data than any other secure vault in this world. In today's world, the easiest way to track people's whereabouts is via their phones. So you should realise that you are holding a powerful device in your hands, and you are responsible for keeping your data safe.

People use smartphones to stay organised, set reminders or keep notes about ideas. Some of the apps use centralised servers to store the data. What users do not realise is that you lose control of your data when you trust a centralised server that is owned by a corporation you don't know. You are kept ignorant about how your data is being used and protected. If an attacker can compromise that centralised server, then your data could be at risk. To make things even more complicated, an attacker could erase all that precious data and you wouldn't even know about it.

Most of the apps in the Google Play store are closed source. Some apps are malicious in nature, working against the interests of the user. Some apps keep tabs on you, or worse, they can steal the most confidential data from your device without your knowledge. Some apps act as tools for promoting non-free services or software by carrying ads. Several studies reveal that these apps track their users' locations and store other background information about them.

You may think of this as paranoia, but the thing is that cyber criminals thrive on the ignorance of the public. It may be argued that most users do not have any illegal secrets in the phone, nor are they important people, so why should they worry about being monitored? Thinking along those lines resembles the man who ignores an empty gun at his door step. He may not use that gun, but is completely ignorant of the fact that someone else might use that gun and frame him for murder.

Replicant

Despite the facts that stack up against Android, it is almost impossible to underestimate its benefits. For a while, Linux was considered a 'nerdy' thing, used only by developers, hackers and others in research. Typically, those in the 'normal' user community did not know much about Linux. After the arrival of